

A KICK IN THE REAR, IF WELL DELIVERED, IS A SURE LAUGH

CHILDREN OF PARADISE / 1945

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Romantic drama

DIRECTOR

Marcel Carné

WRITER

Jacques Prévert

STARS

Arletty, Jean-Louis Barrault, Pierre Brasseur, Marcel Herrand, Louis Salou

BEFORE

1939 US historical romance *Gone with the Wind* is released.

1942 Set in 1485, *The Night Visitors* is the first movie made during World War II by Carné and Prévert with Arletty.

AFTER

1946 Carné and Prévert reunite to make *Gates of the Night*, but it is a flop and they never work together again.

Among the many great landmarks of French cinema, *Children of Paradise* (*Les enfants du paradis*), made at the height of the German occupation in 1943 and 1944, is now seen as among the very greatest. With a compelling script by the poet Jacques Prévert, director Marcel Carné turned a story set in 1830s Paris about four different men's love for the enigmatic courtesan Garance into a profound and romantic drama.

The movie itself is glorious. But what makes the achievement of Carné and Prévert all the more extraordinary is the degree of difficulty they overcame even making it in occupied France. Practically, materials for sets and costumes were almost nonexistent: fruit and loaves of bread intended to be used on camera were eaten by half-starved crew members. Under the eye of the Nazis and the Vichy French regime, every move was monitored. And yet Carné's invention—and independence—triumphed.

Shooting in Vichy France

The ambition and scale of the movie required a large cast and production team. The cast included Nazi collaborators, whom the producers had been coerced into hiring. But what the Vichy overseers didn't know was that Carné had found a place for Resistance fighters among the 1,800 extras, using the movie as daytime cover for their clandestine

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A film poem on the nature and varieties of love—sacred and profane, selfless and possessive.

Pauline Kael

5001 Nights at the Movies, 1982

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